The Safety and Support Conversation Checklist

What to map, notice and ask while your mother's week is running smoothly.

Your mother is doing fine at home, and the help around her has settled into a routine nobody ever wrote down: your sister's Tuesday drive, the neighbor who looks in most mornings, your Sundays. This checklist is for a week when nothing is pressing. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to get to when there's time, and it says nothing about how your mother is managing.

Map

- [ ] An ordinary week of help, written down by day: who comes by, who calls, who drives, and who handles the standing jobs like the pill box, the bills or the groceries.
- [ ] The times of an ordinary day and night when she is on her own, written as times and nothing more.
- [ ] What each piece of help counts on: someone's work schedule, where they live, their car, their own family.
- [ ] Next to each helper, who could cover for a week. Where nobody has been asked, write “nobody yet.”
- [ ] Any instructions her doctor or another professional has already given her, and where they are written down.

Notice

- [ ] Anything you've seen about her balance or how she gets around, written as what you saw, where and when.
- [ ] Anything you've noticed about how her medications go in an ordinary week, written down for her doctor or pharmacist to review. Change nothing yourself.
- [ ] Anything around the house that you've seen or she has mentioned, as one specific thing in one specific place.

Ask

- [ ] Your mother: how the week looks from her side, and what she would add to the map or take off it. [1]
- [ ] Each person who helps: how it is going on their end, and whether the day and the time still suit them. [1]
- [ ] One person who might cover: whether they'd be open to it in principle, with nothing asked of them yet.
- [ ] Which professional each concern goes to: her doctor, her pharmacist or your care consultant.
- [ ] Each other: who will follow up on each item, and what would bring the family back to this page.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you write down, notice and ask. It doesn't say whether the help around your mother is enough, whether her home is safe, or whether anything should change. Those are questions for the professionals who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You've mapped who helps, noticed a few things and asked the people involved. The care interview walks you through your mother's situation area by area, so the parts nobody thought to write down get asked about too, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Items marked 1 follow AARP's planning guide for families, which says to plan with the person the plan is about and to ask the people who help about their preferences. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families